

FAMILY FEUDS From left, Sharad Pawar in Baramati in April; nephew Ajit Pawar at a Mumbai event of his NCP faction in August

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AFTER THE CRUSHING DEFEATS IN THE LS POLL, AJIT HAS HIS BACK AGAINST THE WALL. HE NEEDS TO NOTCH UP A RESPECTABLE NUMBER OF SEATS TO AVERT POLITICAL OBLIVION

and symbol—a man blowing the tutari (turha). Realising that the chips are down, some of Ajit's men, like Nimbalkar and former minister Rajendra Shingane, are queuing up to return to the senior Pawar's side; many more are said to be on the fence. "Saheb (as Pawar Sr is known) is getting mass support as they see in him a leader who stands up to the depredations of the powers in Delhi, something that has resonance in the state's history," says an associate of the Pawars. Indeed, Pawar Sr has never seemed as popular as he is now.

When Ajit was co-opted by the Mahayuti in 2023 (incidentally, just days after Prime Minister Narendra Modi made a "Rs 70,000 crore scam" allegation against the NCP), he was seen as the one who would deliver the goods for the BJP in Maharashtra in the Lok Sabha polls, something that Shinde could not. Ajit's supporters even projected him as CM-in-waiting. But now Shinde is the man holding all the cards and Ajit, who is fighting with his back against the wall, needs to notch up a respectable number of seats to avert political oblivion. There are indications that he may end up with the least number of seats in the alliance—around 60—against the BJP's 160 and Shinde's 70. Ajit still has a few things going for him, though. For one, the BJP has no game plan to take on Sharad Pawar in western Maharashtra where Ajit is still their best bet; and two, the original NCP's local satraps are mostly with the nephew, a big advantage in the "franchisee model" of operations it runs in party strongholds.

Advantage Sharad

- Pawar Sr is seen as the MVA's glue, the man who is leading the fightback
- The NCP (SCP) trounced Ajit's faction in the LS poll, won 8 seats to the latter's one
- Pawar Sr's popularity at an all-time high, has the sympathy of undivided NCP's core voters, rural masses
- Possible Maratha consolidation in some regions will help

Advantage Ajit

- Ajit has some 40 NCP MLAs in his stable, along with official party name, 'clock' symbol
- As finance minister, has tried to take credit for 'Ladki Bahin' dole scheme for women
- Ajit still the go-to man for the BJP in western Maharashtra. Party's 'franchisee model' operations a big plus
- Ajit's pink, pro-woman image makeover may help him